



Trinity College Dublin

Coláiste na Tríonóide, Baile Átha Cliath

The University of Dublin

Semantics I

Week 9: Thematic Roles and Event Structure

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Trinity College Dublin

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Thematic Role Inventories

Why thematic roles matter

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- They sit at the **syntax–semantics interface**:
 - semantically, they tell us what kind of participant an argument is;
 - syntactically, they are linked to subjecthood, objecthood, and case.
- They are therefore useful in semantics for several reasons:

Breaking Windows

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2-children SM2-FUT-carry-APPL-FV 9-chief 14-bow

‘The children will carry the bow for the chief.’

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Syntax, case, and realisation

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Theta Criterion and UTAH

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- So if thematic structure is systematic, syntax ought to reflect that systematically.

Localist roles and paths

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- Examples:
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 - ④ He strayed from the truth.

Paths

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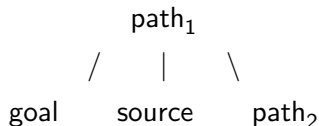
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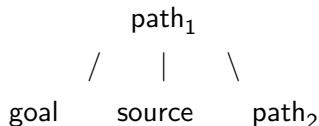
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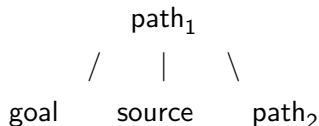
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Role	Example
goal	to the lighthouse
source	from the mirror
path ₂ (open path)	along the beach

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From grids to LCS

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causer = x in $x \text{ CAUSE } [\dots]$

theme_{COS} = y in $BECOME[predicate(y)]$

goal = z in $BECOME[be-at(y, z)]$

Dowty, proto-roles, and psych verbs

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